How Beliefs Influence Personality

Brian Campbell, Ph.D.

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If you want to understand a person, understand what that person believes. Beliefs shape how we think, how we feel, and how we act. They help form our personality, drive or drain our motivation, and lie at the root of most emotional and spiritual struggles. This article explains how beliefs develop, how they shape personality, how false beliefs lead to problems, and how Christian counselors can help people replace those lies with God's truth.

What Is a Belief?

A belief is something we assume to be true. The important word is *assume*. Not everything we believe is actually true. Some beliefs line up with reality and with God's Word, and they lead toward mental and spiritual health. Others are false. In Belief Counseling we call these false beliefs "lies," and they lead toward distress and dysfunction.

Many of the lies people believe are taught to them by the world around them. The truth comes from God, revealed in Scripture and made real to us by the Holy Spirit. Because what we believe affects our thinking, emotions, and behavior, beliefs can have a profound effect on the course of a life.

The role of the Christian counselor follows from this: help clients **identify** their false beliefs, **challenge** them, and **replace** them with biblical truth.

Beliefs and Personality

The single most important concept for understanding human personality is the concept of belief. Personality can be thought of as a complex set of beliefs a person holds about God, self, others, and the world. A person's core beliefs reflect, and to a large degree make up, his or her personality.

Personalities differ because people hold different kinds of beliefs. Different underlying belief patterns produce different personality styles. A person who believes "People will hurt me if I let them close" will develop a very different way of relating than a person who believes "Most people can be trusted."

Much of this begins at home, as parents pass their beliefs on to their children. Beliefs are not the whole story, however. Personality is also influenced by biology:

genetic makeup, temperament, and inborn sensitivities. When a person's core beliefs are deeply maladaptive and rigid, the result can be the long-standing patterns of difficulty that clinicians call personality disorders.

Beliefs and Motivation

Beliefs are a powerful source of motivation, or of the lack of it. We tend to act in ways that are consistent with what we believe, so different beliefs move people in different directions:

- Belief in Jesus Christ and the truths of the Bible can motivate a person to be giving, caring, and loving.
- A belief that money and possessions bring happiness can motivate a person to pursue wealth above all else.
- A person who believes "I'm stupid" may see no point in pursuing an education.
- A child who is repeatedly told "You're lazy" may come to believe it and stop trying.

When a client seems to lack motivation, it is worth asking what he or she believes. Low motivation is often a symptom of a faulty belief rather than a flaw of character.

How Beliefs Develop

Most beliefs are learned, and they accumulate over a lifetime. Parents are the most important early teachers. The Bible charges parents with this responsibility:

> *Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.* (Proverbs 22:6, BSB)

Parents teach their children beliefs about the world, themselves, other people, and God. Some of these beliefs are healthy and true. Others are "toxic." Often without meaning to, parents can pass on lies such as "You'll never amount to anything" or "Love has to be earned." The secular world, through culture, media, peers, and bullies, adds many more.

Children's ability to evaluate beliefs grows with their development:

- **Young children** believe almost anything their parents tell them. Their developing brains limit their reasoning, so their beliefs are simple and childlike, and they rarely question whether something is true.
- **As children mature** and the brain develops, they become able to hold more complex beliefs and begin to question what they have been taught.
- **By adulthood**, many beliefs learned early have become automatic. They are rarely examined, even when they are causing pain.

For this reason, counseling with children often focuses on correcting false beliefs taught by parents or by the world, and on teaching children the truth about God and how God sees them.

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Why People Differ

No two people hold exactly the same set of beliefs. Each person's experiences are different, so each person's beliefs are different. Family, culture, nationality, community, and church background all shape the messages a person receives. So do the different expectations families and cultures often place on boys and girls. A wise counselor does not assume a client shares his or her own beliefs, but takes time to learn what this particular person was taught and has come to believe.

Where Problems Begin

The root cause of most emotional and spiritual problems is belief in lies. These false beliefs usually begin in childhood and are added to throughout life. They come from many sources:

- Parents and family
- The secular world and its values
- Satan, whom Jesus called "the father of lies" (John 8:44)
- Even trusted authorities such as pastors and teachers, who sometimes pass on distorted teaching without realizing it

A Working Definition of Mental Health

Mental health is associated with believing the truth. Jesus Christ is the source of all truth:

> *I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.* (John 14:6, BSB)

Belief in Jesus Christ is the starting point for true mental health. Faith in Christ leads us to accept and believe the truths of the Bible. The Holy Spirit, whom Jesus called the Advocate (John 14:26; "Counselor" in some translations), is also a source of truth, teaching us and reminding us of what Christ has said.

Our journey into mental health is a journey into the truth, and the truth sets us free (John 8:32). The evidence of that health can be seen in the fruit of the Spirit: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control (Galatians 5:22–23).

A Working Definition of Mental Illness

Most psychological problems can be traced to false beliefs: lies about ourselves, our world, and God. These maladaptive core beliefs distort thinking, stir up painful emotions, and drive unhealthy behavior.

False beliefs affect the whole person. They produce **psychological problems** in thinking, emotions, and behavior, and **spiritual problems** that can distance us from God. The deepest spiritual illness is failure to believe in Jesus Christ as Lord and Savior. Both our flesh and our spirit are affected by the lies we believe.

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Integration and Multitasking

Christian Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy (CCBT), the approach on which Belief Counseling is built, fully integrates psychology and theology. It is an extension of secular cognitive-behavioral therapy (CBT). Proven techniques from cognitive therapy and from behavior therapy (including behavior modification) are brought into a Christian framework, where they are joined with Scripture, prayer, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

CCBT also requires multitasking. False beliefs rarely have a single source, so the counselor gathers information from many directions at once. In Belief Counseling this is called **Belief Mining**: looking for the lies across six levels of analysis: biological/physical, psychological/cognitive, interpersonal, socioeconomic, sociocultural, and spiritual.

Finding the Source of the Problem

To find where a client's false beliefs began and how they developed, the counselor draws on several sources of information:

- The clinical interview and the client's own words
- Educational, family, religious, medical, and work history
- Questionnaires and checklists
- Formal psychological testing when appropriate, such as personality inventories like the Millon Clinical Multiaxial Inventory (MCMI-IV)
- Medical problems and physical conditions, and how they have affected what the client believes about self, God, and the future

Once the underlying false beliefs are identified, the counselor plans interventions to challenge them, break them up, and replace them with biblical truth.

The Process: Identify, Challenge, Replace

The heart of the model is simple: identify the lies, challenge them, and replace them with the truth, because the truth sets people free.

1. Identify false beliefs (the lies)

- Client history and clinical interview
- Checklists and questionnaires
- Formal psychological tests

2. Challenge false beliefs

- Questioning the belief ("Thoughtbusters")
- Scripture
- Prayer
- Cognitive refutations
- Helping the client make behavioral changes that "argue against" the false belief
- Behavioral experiments that test whether the belief is actually true

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3. Replace false beliefs with biblical truth

- Positive, truth-focused corrective statements
- Scripture memorization
- Changing activities and habits

How Effective Can We Expect It to Be?

There is good reason to expect CCBT to be effective. It draws on CBT, which has one of the strongest research records of any psychotherapy for depression, anxiety, and many other problems. Studies of religiously integrated CBT have generally found it to work as well as standard CBT, and many Christian clients prefer an approach that honors their faith. CCBT adds the resources of Scripture, prayer, and the Holy Spirit, which secular approaches leave out.

The Worldview Behind the Model

To embrace CCBT, a counselor must hold a worldview that brings together psychology and faith. A foundational assumption is that **all truth is God's truth**: what is genuinely true in psychology does not conflict with Scripture, because both come from the same Creator.

A Christian worldview is at the heart of the model. Belief in Jesus Christ, the truth of Scripture, the power of prayer, and the work of the Holy Spirit are all essential. For this reason CCBT is meant for counselors who share a Christian worldview. Its strength is that it builds on scientifically established treatment methods and extends them into the Christian faith.

In short, CCBT is traditional CBT extended to include biblical truth. Integration is not an add-on to the model; it is the model.

> *Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind.* (Romans 12:2, BSB)

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